



FREE SME PARTNER RESOURCE | VERSION 1.0.2

Small-Business Administration Readiness Checklist

Find the administrative gaps that cost time, weaken cash flow and make a growing business harder to control.

Purpose: Use this checklist to establish what is working now, what is only partly working and what must be fixed next. It is suitable for owners, business-support programmes and practical administration workshops.

BUSINESS DETAILS

BUSINESS NAME

COMPLETED BY

INDUSTRY / ACTIVITY

ASSESSMENT DATE

EMAIL / TELEPHONE

NEXT REVIEW DATE

Privacy note: Entries remain in the copy you save; this checklist does not transmit information to DokKit. For best results, download the PDF, open it in a current PDF reader and save a copy after completion.

HOW TO COMPLETE THE CHECKLIST

Choose one response for every statement. Base the answer on evidence you can produce today, not what you intend to create.

YES = 2	PARTLY = 1	NO = 0	N/A
Working, current and used consistently.	Exists, but incomplete, outdated or inconsistent.	Missing or not working in practice.	Genuinely does not apply. Exclude it from the maximum.

SCORING

Score % = Points earned / Maximum available points x 100

Maximum available points = number of applicable statements x 2. Exclude N/A answers.

Round to the nearest whole percentage. If every answer is N/A, record N/A. Example: 12 / 16 x 100 = 75%.

0% - 39%	Administration at risk	Critical records or routines are missing. Fix cash, customer and legal-risk gaps first.
40% - 59%	Basic systems in place	Some controls exist, but gaps and inconsistent use still expose the business.
60% - 79%	Developing	The foundation is useful. Standardise weak areas and make the routines consistent.
80% - 100%	Well organised	Core systems are working. Maintain them and improve only where the evidence shows a gap.

EVIDENCE RULE: If you cannot retrieve the record or demonstrate a working process, mark Partly or No. If you are unsure whether a legal requirement applies, mark Partly and verify it; do not use N/A for an unknown obligation.

CRITICAL-GAP RULE: A high percentage does not cancel a serious gap. Treat any No affecting cash, customer commitments, statutory obligations, workers or personal information as a priority.

1. Business identity and statutory records

Can you prove who the business is, how it operates, and which obligations apply?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	The business name, contact details and address are consistent across customer-facing documents.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Registration or ownership records can be retrieved quickly, where registration applies.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Tax reference details and important SARS correspondence are stored securely and are up to date.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	Required licences, permits, certificates or professional registrations are identified and monitored.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	Business banking and payment details are verified, controlled and clearly separated from personal use.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	A simple register shows key records, renewal dates and the person responsible for each item.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

2. Pricing, quotations and invoicing

Can the business price consistently, obtain approval and request payment professionally?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	A current written price list or pricing method is used instead of pricing from memory.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Costs, mark-ups and discounts are reviewed so that sales are not made unknowingly at a loss.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Quotations are numbered, dated, valid for a stated period and saved for future reference.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	Customer approval is recorded before work starts, goods are ordered or a booking is confirmed.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	Invoices contain the required business and transaction details; VAT is charged or shown only where the business is registered and the supply is taxable.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	Payment terms, deposit rules, due dates and verified payment details are stated clearly.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

3. Customer, order and agreement records

Can every customer commitment be traced from request to completion?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	Customer or client requirements are captured in writing before the business commits to delivery.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Only necessary customer information is collected, and contact preferences are recorded.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Terms and conditions, cancellation rules and important limitations are supplied before acceptance.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	Recurring, customised, high-value or higher-risk work is supported by a suitable written agreement.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	A booking, order or job tracker shows the reference number, owner, status, due date and amount.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	Completion, delivery, acceptance, complaints and agreed resolutions are recorded.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

4. Income, expenses and payment control

Can the owner explain where the money came from, where it went and what remains outstanding?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	Every sale and payment received is recorded, including cash, card, EFT and digital payments.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Every business expense is recorded and supported by a receipt, invoice or acceptable proof.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Business and personal money are kept separate or clearly identified when separation is not yet possible.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	Cash, bank and payment-platform balances are checked against records at least weekly.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	Amounts owed by customers are reviewed and followed up using a consistent process.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	A monthly review covers income, expenses, profit, cash needs and known tax obligations.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

5. Daily operations and quality control

Can the business deliver consistently when work becomes busy or someone is absent?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	Repeat work has a simple checklist, workflow or standard operating procedure.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Each job, order or task has a responsible person, status and realistic deadline.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Stock, tools, equipment or important digital assets are counted, maintained or backed up as relevant.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	A quality check is completed before goods, services or documents are handed to the customer.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	Mistakes, incidents, returns or complaints are logged, resolved and reviewed for recurring causes.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	There is a practical backup plan for data loss, equipment failure, supplier disruption or owner absence.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

6. Staff and contractor administration

If other people work in the business, are responsibilities and records clear?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	Each working relationship is reviewed so the person is correctly treated and documented as an employee, contractor, temporary worker or service provider.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Written agreements describe duties or deliverables, payment, confidentiality and termination arrangements.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Required employee records, hours, pay, leave and supporting documents are maintained where applicable.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	UIF, PAYE, COIDA, minimum-wage and other employment obligations are checked where employees are used.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	New workers receive role, safety, conduct, customer-service and information-handling guidance.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	Contractor invoices, work approvals, deliverables and access to business information are controlled.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

7. POPIA, records and information security

Is personal and business information handled deliberately rather than casually?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	The business knows what personal information it collects, why it needs it and where it is stored.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Customers, workers and other people receive an appropriate privacy notice where required.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Before electronic direct marketing, the business records consent or a permitted existing-customer basis and keeps objections and opt-outs.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	Access to devices, email, cloud storage and sensitive files is limited and protected by strong security.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	Important records are backed up and can be restored without relying on one device or one person.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	Retention, secure disposal and response to an information breach are addressed in a basic written process.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

8. Weekly and monthly administration discipline

Do routines keep the records useful after the initial setup?

#	Readiness statement	Yes	Partly	No	N/A
1	Sales, expenses, orders and customer records are updated at least weekly.	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	A month-end routine checks missing documents, reconciliations and unfinished transactions.	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	Overdue quotations, invoices, bookings and supplier matters are reviewed and followed up.	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	Templates, prices, terms, contact details and compliance dates are reviewed when circumstances change.	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	A few useful measures - such as sales, profit, cash, overdue debt and job status - are reviewed monthly.	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	Administration gaps are assigned to a person with a due date and checked at the next review.	☐	☐	☐	☐
SECTION COUNTS		Y ☐	P ☐	N ☐	N/A ☐

Your readiness result

For each section, calculate Earned, Available and Section %. Mark Priority when the section contains a critical No or a material Partly gap. Use the evidence and the percentage - not optimism - to choose the readiness band.

Section	Earned	Available	Section %	Priority?
Business identity and statutory records				☐
Pricing, quotations and invoicing				☐
Customer, order and agreement records				☐
Income, expenses and payment control				☐
Daily operations and quality control				☐
Staff and contractor administration				☐
POPIA, records and information security				☐
Weekly and monthly administration discipline				☐

TOTAL EARNED

TOTAL AVAILABLE

OVERALL %

READINESS BAND

Top five actions

#	Gap to close / action to complete	Owner	Due date	Done
1				☐
2				☐
3				☐
4				☐
5				☐

30-day review

NEXT 7 DAYS

BY DAY 30

NEXT REVIEW DATE

Need help closing the gaps? DokKit provides editable Word and Excel administration templates designed for South African small businesses. Visit www.dokkit.co.za.

Important: This checklist is a practical self-assessment and readiness indicator, not legal, tax, accounting or regulatory advice or a certification of compliance. All applicable statements are weighted equally for simplicity. Requirements differ by industry, business structure and circumstances. Confirm material obligations with an appropriately qualified professional or the relevant authority.
Official reference points: SARS | Information Regulator | Department of Employment and Labour

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